

VAHAN TOTOVENTS, one of the leading Armenian writers of this century, was born in 1893, in Western Armenia, in the small country town of Mezré, about 150 miles to the south of the Black Sea port of Trebizond. He was one of seven children, and he was only eight when he lost his father—a prosperous landowner and a high government official. After an elementary education, the young Totovents went to the Armenian Central School in the large nearby town of Kharpert, where two of his teachers were well-known authors, who influenced his style of writing, despite its individuality. His first book appeared in 1908. The following year he went to America, where he worked as a salesman in a store. At the same time, he mastered English and French, and studied literature, history, and philosophy at the University of Wisconsin.

During the First World War, in 1915, Totovents went to the Caucasus as a volunteer in defence of his country: this was the year in which the whole of Western Armenia was depleted of its Armenian population during the notorious Turkish massacres and deportations. He was actively engaged in the efforts to relieve the untold misery, famine, and epidemics, brought about by refugees fleeing across the border into Eastern Armenia. He edited a newspaper in Tiflis in 1917-18, wrote numerous articles, a novel, literary studies and other material. In 1920 he again went to America, and two years later he returned to Eastern Armenia, by this time known as Soviet Armenia, where he devoted all his time to writing. His output comprised novels, short stories, plays, and poems.

His most famous work, *Life on the Old Roman Road*, was written and first published in 1930. Its English translation, published in London in 1962 under the title *Scenes from an Armenian Childhood*, was an outstanding literary success. It deals with the author's reminiscences of life in Western Armenia in the 'nineties, with its colourful background.

Totovents had intended writing a long novel about the blood-stained and heroic history of the Armenian people with their miraculous resurgence from the ashes of the Black Year of 1915